

Political Theory Comprehensive Exam, August 2025

Answer three questions, one from each part

Your exam will be evaluated as a whole, so avoid repeating yourself

Part One

1. Discuss three arguments or insights in Plato's writings that are of continuing relevance to understanding politics today. What do we miss by failing to attend to them?
2. What was most innovative about Hobbes's *Leviathan* at the time he wrote it? Which of his insights or arguments have been most enduring? Why?
3. Tocqueville thought it possible to gain general insights about politics from his study of American democracy. What were his principal claims, and how successfully have they endured?
4. Marx was wrong about many things, yet he remains one of the most widely read theorists of all time. What were his enduring insights? If there aren't any, why does he continue to be read?

Part Two

5. Is there such a thing as a legitimate state? If so, where does this legitimacy come from and when can it come apart? Answer by reference to at least three authors on the list.
6. How useful it is to think about politics by reference to the idea of a social contract? Discuss with reference to at least three authors on the list.
7. How accurate, and how useful, is it to think of Amartya Sen and Alasdair MacIntyre as Aristotelians?
8. Discuss any two debates among political theorists that could benefit from paying attention to Albert Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty*.

Part Three

9. Miranda Fricker distinguishes between *testimonial injustice* and *hermeneutical injustice* as forms of epistemic injustice. Explain each concept and discuss how they might manifest in the political sphere. Using at least one concrete political example, assess whether Fricker's framework adequately captures the structural dimensions of epistemic oppression, or whether it needs to be supplemented by other theoretical tools (e.g., standpoint theory, critical race theory, feminist political theory).

10. What are the most important questions about power that have not been asked in the “faces of power” debate? How might they best be addressed?
11. What is rationality, and what does it have to do with politics? Discuss with reference to three authors on your list.
12. Sheldon Wolin views democracy as the episodic and disruptive exercise of popular power. What is the appeal and what are the risks of a theory of democracy that deflates institutions?

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9. How can we read Lilla's critique of identity politics in light of Benhabib's attempt to theorize the democratic inclusion of difference? To what extent does Benhabib's model offer a normative response to the concerns Lilla raises about fragmentation, and to what extent does Lilla expose limits or blind spots in Benhabib's deliberative-democratic project?

10. Judith Shklar claims that the democratization of America resulted from marginalized groups fighting for inclusion through suffrage and economic independence. To what extent and in what ways does such an interpretation of American history challenge a liberalism based on rights enshrined in the Constitution?
11. “Isaiah Berlin’s distinction between negative and positive liberty was not a helpful addition to debates on the subject.” Criticize or defend this view by reference to three authors on your list.
12. What were the characteristic features of Cold War liberals that distinguished them from other liberals? Discuss with reference to at least three authors on your list.

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9. Charles Mills argues that ideal theory in political philosophy can function as an ideology that obscures injustice by abstracting away from actual social conditions. Explain Mills' distinction between *ideal* and *nonideal* theory and discuss his claim that ideal theory often serves to reinforce rather than challenge oppressive structures. Using at least one concrete example from political life, evaluate whether Mills's critique calls for the abandonment of ideal theory altogether or for its radical reform. In your answer, consider possible objections from defenders of ideal theory.

10. For Charles Mills, ideal theory risks becoming ideology. For Karuna Mantena, British ideology justifying colonial rule in India used “alibis” such as historical arguments. What assumptions do their respective arguments make about the relations between political ideals and political ideologies? Whose is more convincing? Why?
11. Anthony Downs maintained that it is rational for voters to remain ignorant of most details about politics and public policy. Evaluate his claim by reference to at least three other authors on your list.
12. What, if anything, does identity have to do with political rationality? Discuss with reference to three authors on your list